Zelenskyy fights for Europe's attention

送信者: POLITICO Brussels Playbook 受信日時: 2026-10-16 13:39

【メール原文】

Presented by EFPIA By SEBASTIAN STARCEVIC with MAX GRIERA GOOD MORNING. This is Sebastian Starcevic, bleary-eyed after a European Council summit that,

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GOOD MORNING. This is Sebastian Starcevic, bleary-eyed after a European Council summit that, as usual, dragged long into the night. Read on for our recap of what went down — and what to expect during Round 2 today.

In today's Playbook:

— Ukraine's president is fighting to regain Brussels' full attention.

— Everything you need to know from Day 1 of the EU summit.

— Faces in the crowd: Volodymyr Zelenskyy, Ursula von der Leyen, Nikos Christodoulides, Donald Trump, Bart De Wever, Oliver Tanzer, Gabrielius Landsbergis and more …

On today's Brussels Playbook Week Ender: Sarah is live from the European Council with Zoya, Tim and Gregorio, looking at what went off the rails last night and what's on tap today.

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A message from EFPIA:The rest of the world is not standing still. Across the US, China and other major markets, governments are competing to attract life sciences research, manufacturing and investment. Europe has recognised the challenge. Now it needs to turn ambition into action and make Europe the place where the next generation of medicines is developed.

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DRIVING THE DAY

COMPETING FOR THE SPOTLIGHT: Volodymyr Zelenskyy faces an uphill battle to keep Ukraine at the front of EU leaders' minds at today's summit in Brussels.

The EU has been Kyiv's staunchest backer throughout its full-scale war with Russia. But mounting concerns about energy prices at home and an impasse over the bloc's budget risk drowning out everything else, including Ukraine's fight for survival.

Zelenskyy will remind leaders what's at stake for his country when he addresses them this morning, but it'll be a tall order to shift their attention from other priorities, a European leader who was granted anonymity due to the sensitivity of the discussions told Playbook.

Is that a snub? It's a sign of how crowded the EU's list of priorities has become that, for the first time since Russia's full-scale invasion in 2022, Ukraine was not the top item on the summit agenda. That honor went to the EU's budget.

Underscoring Kyiv's desperation, the Ukrainian president arrived in Brussels a day earlier than scheduled to meet with leaders bilaterally, including French President Emmanuel Macron on Thursday night. He will also hold his first meeting with Hungarian Prime Minister Péter Magyar on Friday morning.

There's also unease among some EU leaders over how Zelenskyy has handled his fraught relationship with U.S. President Donald Trump, an EU diplomat said, adding that they felt Zelenskyy had been "not helpful" by hitting out at Trump in public statements.

In a briefing just before 1 a.m., Belgian Prime Minister Bart De Wever predicted Zelenskyy would "probably look everybody straight in the eye and say thank you for the €90 billion but that money is going to run out because war is a very costly thing." The Ukrainian president would want to know if the "European family" would come through or not, he added.

Rally round the flag: A second EU diplomat said it was not up to leaders to criticize a president who is fighting an existential war, adding it was unlikely they would actually reprimand him. And a third said Trump's deal with Moscow to import Russian diesel "probably may help" Zelenskyy by encouraging European solidarity.

One thing rising up the agenda: The fraught question of what to do with Russia's frozen financial assets . Sweden, Finland and Germany want to revisit the issue, although EU countries have balked at a U.S. proposal to unfreeze some of the assets and transfer them to a vehicle controlled by Washington to use as leverage in peace talks.

The stakes don't get much higher ⋯ Kyiv is heading into its fifth wartime winter, with its energy infrastructure under constant Russian bombardment and a $35 billion budget shortfall next year, according to IMF projections. Gabrielius Landsbergis, Lithuania's former foreign minister, diagnosed the situation as "extremely grim," telling Playbook that "everything falls on European shoulders now."

"The Europeans have been kicking the can down the road," Landsbergis said, referring to their efforts to sustain Ukraine. "And the proverbial can is hurling back at us."

Follow all the action from Day 2 of the summit in our live blog .

BIG AND BREAKING

MEANWHILE, ON THE FRONT LINES: Ukraine is running critically low on U.S.-made interceptor missiles, leaving it more vulnerable to Russian ballistic missile attacks, per CNN and the Washington Post .

FROM THE TOP: The order to limit Ukraine's use of the vital Starshield satellite service came from the White House, Reuters reported overnight , citing American and Western officials.

PLAN C: The U.S. is considering easing restrictions on Russian and Iranian "shadow fleet" tankers in its latest bid to relieve pressure on diesel prices, the FT reports .

OUTDATED: Big tech bosses are questioning whether the EU's two-year-old AI law is still fit for purpose amid growing concerns about the technology's risks to humanity, Pieter Haeck and Mathieu Pollet report.

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DAY 1 RECAP

ROUGH DAY FOR COSTA: If you went to bed before Day 1 of the summit wrapped up late last night, we've got you covered on the two biggest fights: a drawn-out brawl over the bloc's carbon pricing scheme, and a less explosive exchange over the EU's stalled €2 trillion budget.

Budget battle rolls on: What was expected to be the most contentious topic of the day, the EU's seven-year budget, saw no big breakthroughs or fireworks. The odds of leaders in the two deeply entrenched rival camps reaching a deal by the end of the year look vanishingly slim , an EU diplomat said, even though Emmanuel Macron gave Costa a boost by urging fellow leaders not to delay . Spain's election in November throws a further spanner in the works.

That doesn't bode well: In a sign of how dire the state of negotiations is, Cyprus' President Nikos Christodoulides told Playbook in an interview during a break in the talks that leaders should consider an unprecedented three- or four-year budget.

"We're discussing the budget in 2034 and now we're in 2026," Christodoulides said, arguing that a shorter budget might be easier for some member countries to swallow. "Why not open the political discussion?" he argued.

ETS WTF: While the budget may have been a bit of a nothingburger, the bloc's energy policy — specifically its Emissions Trading System (ETS) — ended up almost derailing the whole evening, with Italy and Central European countries clashing with the Nordics and others over the wording of the summit's conclusions.

Ouch: An EU diplomat couldn't contain their frustration, telling me that European Council President António Costa had allowed the talks to go "off the rails" … was behaving "worse than Charles Michel," his predecessor as Council president … and hadn't "read the room."

A second EU diplomat agreed there was “huge frustration” with Costa, saying the Council president forced leaders to spend “half the day in a drafting exercise” and hadn’t managed the discussion properly.

The ETS talks went on so long that a planned press conference with Costa and European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen was canceled — an embarrassing flub for Costa, who has mostly sailed through his presidency as a well-liked consensus-builder until now. Read our full story on that here .

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

The College of Europe’s office in Tirana was set on fire during protests in Albania, but what is the college and where is it based? It’s a training ground for EU civil servants and the world’s oldest postgraduate institute of European studies, offering one-year master’s programs. Its main base is in Bruges, where it has been since 1950. It opened another campus in Natolin, a neighborhood of Warsaw, in 1992 and one in Tirana in 2024.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shout-out.

I DECLARE A ⋯

BRIEFING WAR: The European People’s Party’s battle over its vice chairs is getting ugly. As 12 candidates jostle for the 10 spots, rival camps are furiously briefing the media against each other to sway the vote, which is set for Oct. 20, Max Griera reports.

Boiling over: Despite center-right EPP chief Manfred Weber’s attempts to keep the fighting in-house, five people with knowledge of the race said it is getting feisty. On Thursday evening, POLITICO received an anonymous email purportedly sent by vice chair candidate Andrzej Halicki, apparently urging colleagues to reject Portugal’s Sebastião Bugalho’s bid.

But POLITICO hasn’t been able to verify the identity of the sender, Halicki’s office denied he ever sent such an email, and six of the supposed recipients POLITICO spoke to said they had not seen it. Bugalho’s office said he “will obviously not comment on forged emails.”

The whole affair reveals how heated the race for the powerful posts has become after Weber failed to persuade any candidates to withdraw. The EPP chief tried to roll over the incumbents, but Portugal’s switch from Lídia Pereira to Bugalho threw off the mandatory gender balance, while surprise bids from Eszter Lakos and Danuše Nerudová added fuel to the fire.

3 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

BETTER TOGETHER: The U.K. is ready to work with the EU to counter China’s carmaking dominance, a trade minister told my colleagues — signaling London could back Brussels’ tariffs on EV imports to get access to Made in Europe.

TRUMP’S WANING SHOCK VALUE: EU leaders are increasingly immune to the American president’s antics, Jamie Dettner explains.

LOOK AWAY NOW: Paul Dallison's latest Declassified column considers what Brussels might look like if Marine Le Pen gets her way.

DASHBOARD

Day 2 of the EU leaders' meeting in Brussels will include talks on migration, during which return hubs, a crisis framework to respond to sudden mass movements and a bolstered role for border agency Frontex are bound to come up. They're tense topics — even as irregular border crossings are down and returns are up.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Mostly cloudy, with rain in the late afternoon and a top temperature of 18C.

DOES THIS EXPLAIN AUSTRIA'S POSITION ON THE CAP? Austria's legendary Coreper II spokesperson Oliver Tanzer is leaving Brussels and heading back to Austria to become a farmer in three weeks. He'll be tilling and sowing on his neighbor's property while detoxing from politics, he told Playbook last night. Good thing he got his last shot of EUCO.

JOB CHANGE: There's a new deputy head of cabinet in Culture Commissioner Glenn Micallef's office from today: Agata Dziarnowska, previously in charge of sport policy. She replaces Johanna Bernsel, who is returning to DG GROW.

DRUGS AND BUREAUCRACY: Brussels has found a new way to fight drug crime: arguing over who should coordinate the fight. Prosecutor General Frédéric Van Leeuw called plans for a regional drugs commissioner laughable, pointing out that Belgium already has a national one. Brussels-Capital Region Minister-President Boris Dilliès disagrees, arguing that Brussels needs its own coordinator to get authorities working together. More on BRUZZ .

VOLDEMORT, RACKETS AND HALLOWEEN: Need to recover from the EU summit? Brussels has you covered this weekend, whether you're after a selfie with the Dark Lord, some tennis drama or a head start on Halloween, Gerardo Fortuna writes.

Harry Potter and the Expensive Selfie: Ralph Fiennes (a.k.a. Lord Voldemort) and Matthew Lewis (a.k.a. Neville Longbottom) are coming to Brussels for Heroes World, the pop culture festival at Brussels Expo . But magic doesn't come cheap: A selfie or autograph with Fiennes costs €150, or €290 for both. Lewis is a bargain by comparison: €60 for one, €110 for the combo. Playbook wonders how much a selfie-and-interview combo with Ursula von der Leyen would cost, given how rare the latter is.

Swap the briefings for backhands: The European Open serves up its opening weekend at ING Arena, with ATP 250 qualifying matches starting Saturday . Félix Auger-Aliassime, Arthur Fils and Casper Ruud are among the big names expected before the tournament wraps up Oct. 25. After a week of summit drama, why not watch someone else lose their cool under pressure?

Celebrating 10 years: SINGA Brussels marks a decade of bringing newcomers and locals together with a free festival Saturday at Jardin Hospice. Workshops and games start at 2 p.m., before live music from Fousai Fousaa, Porte des Princes and Zaataric takes over at 6:30 p.m. DJs keep things going until 11:30 p.m. Registration requested.

Spooky shopping: Halloween is coming and Brussels Makers Market is getting into the spirit. Head to Gare Maritime at Tour & Taxis on Sunday for handmade jewelry, art, decorations and gifts from independent creators. Free entry, 11 a.m. to 6 p.m. Perfect for buying something you absolutely don't need — but that will make your colleagues jealous at the office Halloween party.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Friedrich Merz will meet this weekend with a CDU youth wing that is growing increasingly impatient at the pace of reform.

Paris: Raphaël Glucksmann is courting a Green heavyweight to bolster his presidential bid.

Madrid: Spain's divided left is racing a midnight deadline to unite ahead of the Nov. 29 election.

London: Andy Burnham will try to upstage the Scottish National Party's annual conference today with a speech nearby about devolution.

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AGENDA

— Day 2 of the European Council summit in Brussels, with discussions focusing on the EU's support for Ukraine. European Council President António Costa and European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen will meet Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelenskyy before he addresses EU leaders. Follow in our live blog .

Key timings: Arrivals and doorsteps from 8:30 a.m. ⋯ joint doorstep by Costa, von der Leyen and Zelenskyy at 9:20 a.m. ⋯ trilateral meeting at 9:30 a.m. ⋯ exchange of views with Zelenskyy at 10 a.m. ⋯ press conference around 2:30 p.m. Watch here .

— European Parliament President Roberta Metsola chairs a meeting with speakers from the Gulf Cooperation Council at 10:30 a.m.

— At the IMF and World Bank Annual Meetings in Bangkok, Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis participates in the International Monetary and Financial Committee's introductory session on global developments and prospects, as well as in the Ukraine Financial Coordination Group. International Partnerships Commissioner Jozef Síkela meets Tajikistan's Finance Minister Faiziddin Sattorovich Kahhorzoda. ECB President Christine Lagarde is also attending the annual meetings.

— EU Education Ministers continue their informal meeting in Dublin. Executive Vice President Roxana Mînzatu is also participating.

— Defense Commissioner Andrius Kubilius delivers a keynote speech at the Anniversary of the Magna Charta Universitatum MCU2020 in Vilnius.

BIRTHDAYS

MEP Kim van Sparrentak; former MEPs Nosheena Mobarik, Marlene Mortler and Nikolay Barekov; former official at Estonia's Ministry of Economic Affairs Luukas Ilves; Peter M. Christian, former president of the

Federated States of Micronesia.

Celebrating Saturday: MEP Hannes Heide; former MEPs Eva-Maria Poptcheva and Cecilia Wikström; former European Commissioner Elisa Ferreira; Ireland's Tánaiste and Finance Minister Simon Harris; Reporters Without Borders' Bertrand Mossiat; Euroconsumers' Els Bruggeman.

Celebrating Sunday: MEP Adrian-George Axinia; former MEPs Tania González Peñas and Dobromir Sośnierz; IRSEM-Europe's Philippe Perchoc; Sopra Steria Group's Axelle Lemaire; Marion Smith of the Common Sense Society; Austria's permanent representation spokesperson Oliver Tanzer.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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**A message from EFPIA:The global race for medicines innovation is accelerating. Major economies are putting ambitious strategies in place to attract research, investment, manufacturing and talent, recognising life sciences not simply as a healthcare sector, but as a strategic economic asset.Europe has recognised the challenge too and keeping pace with global competitors will require greater ambition.Closing the competitiveness gap with global peers could attract an additional €105 billion in pharmaceutical R&D investment to Europe over the next decade. Catching up with growth in clinical trials in China and North America could add nearly €18 billion to Europe's economy, create 82,000 jobs and give 158,000 more patients the opportunity to participate in clinical trials.These gains are within reach. Europe has the science, talent and industrial base. With policies that make it faster and more attractive to research, develop, manufacture and launch medicines here, Europe can compete for the investment and innovation of tomorrow. **

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